SMACC · FALL 2026 RESEARCH

THE PRE-PRODUCTION MARKETING PLAYBOOK

Six films. Two budgets. What studios should plan before cameras roll.

University of Connecticut

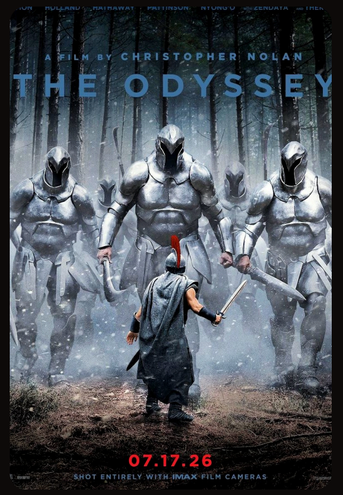
THE QUESTION

WHAT SHOULD A STUDIO LOCK IN BEFORE CAMERAS ROLL TO MAKE A FILM A HIT?

We tracked six recent releases from announcement to streaming, using box office, exit polls, reviews and more than 3,000 coded social posts, to find what the winners had in common at each budget level.

SIX FILMS, TWO BUDGETS

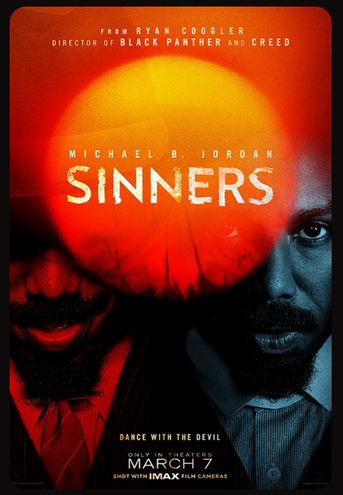
BLOCKBUSTERS · $90M–$250M



The Odyssey



Barbie



Sinners

SMALL BUDGET · $750K–$25M



Obsession



Anyone But You



Backrooms

EIGHT QUESTIONS FOR EVERY FILM

01

Did it work?

Box office, return on cost, beating the forecast

02

How was it received?

Critics vs. regular viewers

03

What was made?

Production pull and budget efficiency

04

Who was in it?

Cast reach, pairing and fan participation

05

How was it sold?

Buzz, audience trust, premium formats

06

Who showed up?

Attendance, reasons and demographics

07

What did people say?

Volume, sentiment, virality and UGC

08

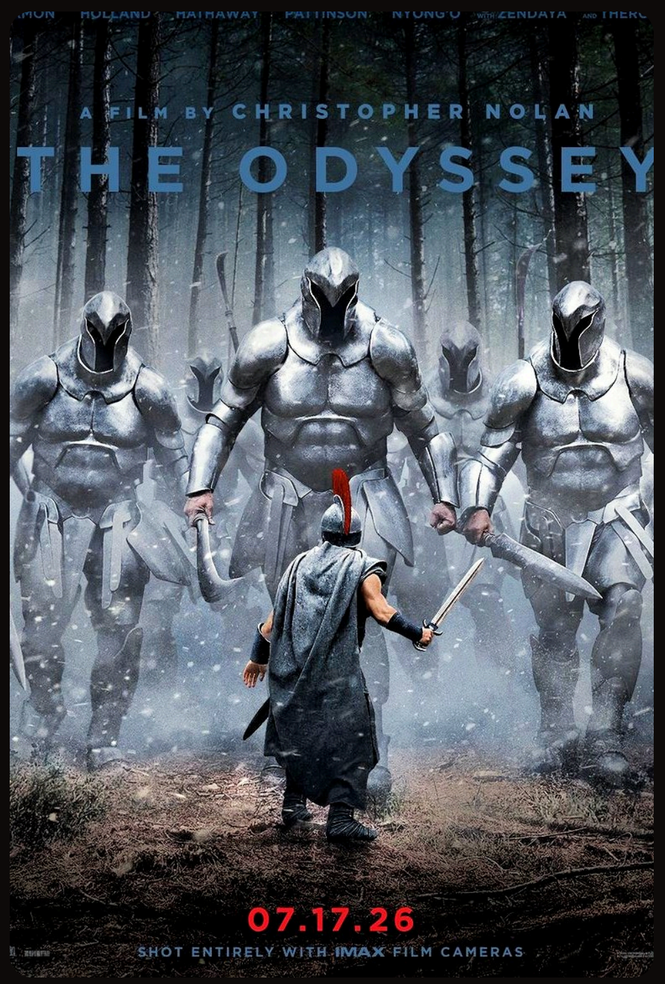
Did it last?

Staying power after opening weekend

PATH A

BLOCKBUSTERS

Three studio tentpoles made for $90M–$250M and released wide by Universal and Warner Bros.



BLOCKBUSTER · UNIVERSAL · 2026

THE ODYSSEY

Scarcity as strategy: a theaters-only teaser and IMAX 70mm tickets on sale a full year early.

$123.5M Opening weekend	**$1.82B** Worldwide gross	**$4.86** Back per $1 spent
1.4× Opening vs. forecast	**94% · A** Critics · CinemaScore	**5.1×** Full run vs. opening

Why it mattered: shooting on IMAX film sold the big screen. Premium screens earned 53% of the opening and IMAX alone $555M worldwide.



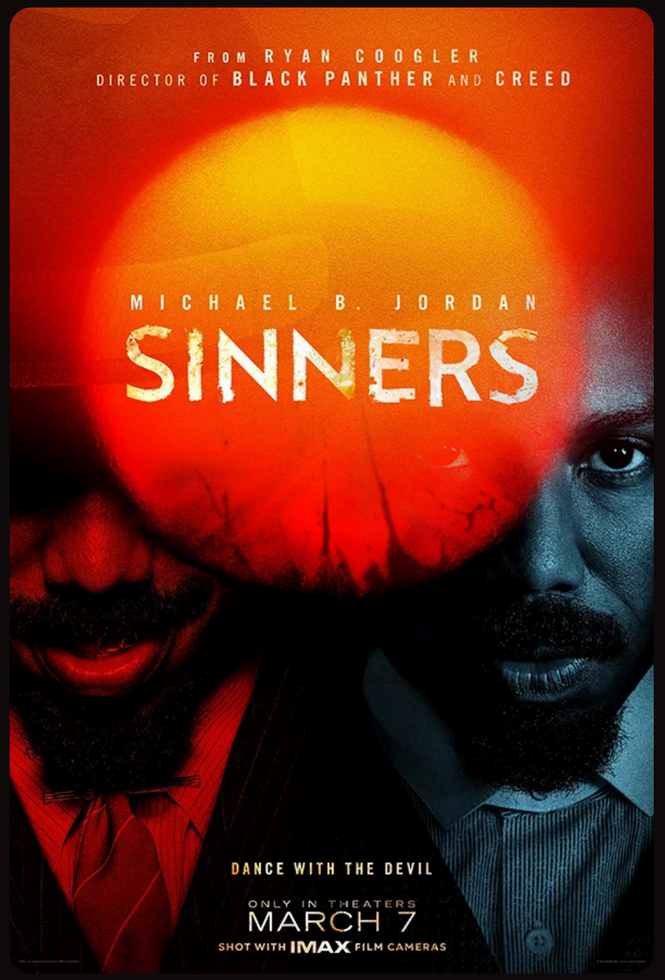
BLOCKBUSTER · WARNER BROS. · 2023

BARBIE

A “breadcrumb” campaign of pink-everything teasers, capped by the Barbenheimer double feature.

$162.0M Opening weekend	**$1.45B** Worldwide gross	**$4.91** Back per $1 spent
2.2× Opening vs. forecast	**88% · A** Critics · CinemaScore	**3.9×** Full run vs. opening

Why it mattered: the pink-paint shortage made set design front-page news 46 days out and helped draw the most female audience of the six (65%).



BLOCKBUSTER · WARNER BROS. · 2025

SINNERS

An original horror film sold on director trust and premium screens, with the vampires held back until trailer two.

$48.0M Opening weekend	**$370.3M** Worldwide gross	**$2.55** Back per $1 spent
1.4× Opening vs. forecast	**97% · A** Critics · CinemaScore	**5.8×** Full run vs. opening

Why it mattered: Coogler's format video sent fans to premium screens (45% of the opening), and the craft earned a record 16 Oscar nominations.

BLOCKBUSTER THROUGH LINE

AT THIS SCALE, OPENING WEEKEND IS THE BET, SO THE CAMPAIGN HAS TO TURN THE RELEASE INTO AN EVENT.

268 days
Average first-trailer lead

$111M
Average opening weekend

50–103%
Marketing as % of budget

$2.55–$4.91
Back for every $1 spent

Start seven months out, or more

First trailers landed 206–380 days before release.

Sell an event, not just a movie

Premium formats, Barbenheimer and year-early presales.

Budget marketing at 0.5–1× production

Reported spend ran $55M–$150M.

Protect the second weekend

All three earned an A CinemaScore and ran 3.9–5.8× their opening.

PLAYBOOK RULE · FAN-MADE CONTENT

EVEN $100M+ CAMPAIGNS RUN ON WHAT FANS MAKE

33%
of The Odyssey’s TikTok views came from fans with under 10,000 followers

13M
people made their own Barbie posters with the Selfie Generator

10.5M
fan-made posts about Sinners in four months (unverified)

Build in something to share: a poster maker, a dress code, a look.

Seed everyday fans, not just big accounts.

Keep feeding fans after opening: premieres, awards, re-releases.

PATH B

SMALL BUDGET

Three films made for $750K–$25M: a creator-made acquisition, a star-driven rom-com and an A24 internet-fandom hit.



SMALL BUDGET · FOCUS FEATURES · 2026

OBSESSION

Cryptic product drops and billboards for a $750K creator-made film that grew in weekends two and three.

$17.2M Opening weekend	**$521.3M** Worldwide gross	**695×** Its $750K budget
1.7× Opening vs. forecast	**93% · A-** Critics · CinemaScore	**15.3×** Full run vs. opening

Why it mattered: the $750K underdog story sold the film to Focus for about $15M, and its prop and makeup became TikTok trends.



SMALL BUDGET · SONY · 2023

ANYONE BUT YOU

Sold on its stars' chemistry and a TikTok trend that turned a soft $6M opening into a long run.

$6.0M Opening weekend	**$219.8M** Worldwide gross	**$2.44** Back per $1 spent
+46% Weekend two vs. one	**53% · 87%** Critics · audiences	**14.7×** Full run vs. opening

Why it mattered: sunny Sydney sold escapism, and the "Unwritten" scene gave fans a moment to recreate: 602M TikTok views.



SMALL BUDGET · A24 · 2026

BACKROOMS

A low-cost, fan-native online campaign riding a fandom that started on YouTube.

$81.4M Opening weekend	**$400.1M** Worldwide gross	**$20.00** Back per $1 spent
4.1× Opening vs. forecast	**85% · B-** Critics · CinemaScore	**2.4×** Full run vs. opening

Why it mattered: real sets rebuilt the yellow rooms fans already loved online; 58% came for the Backrooms story itself.

SMALL-BUDGET THROUGH LINE

ON A SMALL BUDGET, THE AUDIENCE IS THE MARKETING DEPARTMENT, SO BUILD CAMPAIGNS FANS WANT TO SHARE.

$1.14B
Combined worldwide gross

8.8–695×
Earned back their budgets

2 of 3
Grew in weekend two

94–242 days
First-trailer lead

Start with a built-in community

Two of the three came from YouTube creators.

Design participation, not impressions

Text lines, product drops, dances, in-universe ads.

Judge the run, not the opening

Two films ran ~15× their openings; Backrooms 2.4×.

A shorter runway can work

Presales opened just 16–59 days out.

PLAYBOOK RULE · FAN-MADE CONTENT

ON A SMALL BUDGET, FAN CONTENT IS THE MARKETING

602M

views of fans dancing to “Unwritten” as they left Anyone But You

400K

fans signed up to text Obsession’s Nikki

1.1B

views from about 10,000 fan TikToks the month Backrooms opened

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Give fans one thing to copy: a prop, a look, a song, a set.

Spot trends early and join in, as Sony did with the exit dance.

Make it interactive: a text line, a product drop, hidden lore.

SIDE BY SIDE

Film	Budget	Opening	Worldwide	× budget	Full run	Critics	Premium
The Odyssey	$250M	$123.5M	$1.82B	7.3×	5.1×	94%	53%
Barbie	$145M	$162.0M	$1.45B	10.0×	3.9×	88%	10%*
Sinners	$90M	$48.0M	$370.3M	4.1×	5.8×	97%	45%
Obsession	$750K	$17.2M	$521.3M	695×	15.3×	93%	0%
Anyone But You	$25M	$6.0M	$219.8M	8.8×	14.7×	53%	n/a
Backrooms	$10M	$81.4M	$400.1M	40.0×	2.4×	85%	17%

× budget = worldwide gross ÷ production budget. Full run = US total ÷ opening weekend. Critics = Rotten Tomatoes. Premium = share of opening from IMAX and premium screens (*unverified).

THE PLAYBOOK

FIVE RULES FOR ANY BUDGET

01	**Lock the hook in pre-production.** A format, a cast or a creator chosen before the shoot became the campaign.
02	**Lead with a name people trust.** 51% came for Nolan; 58% came for the Backrooms story.
03	**Make one clear promise.** An event to see in theaters, or a question to argue about.
04	**Hand fans something to do.** Fan-made content reached audiences paid ads couldn’t.
05	**Plan for the run, not just the opening.** Films ran 2.4× to 15.3× their opening weekends.

QUESTIONS?

Explore every film on the website, or read the full research in the white paper.

adachalexa.github.io/pre-production-marketing-playbook